



Analgesia Options for Labor

Medications available to help manage labor pain

What types of medications for pain relief are used during labor and delivery?

In general, there are two types of drugs for pain relief: 1) analgesics and 2) anesthetics. Analgesics lessen pain without loss of feeling or

muscle movement. Anesthetics relieve pain by blocking most feeling, including pain. Pain relief medications can be either systemic,

regional, or local. Systemic medications affect the entire body. Local medications affect only a small area of the body. Regional

medications affect a region of the body, like the region below the waist.

What are systemic analgesics?

Systemic analgesics reduce your awareness of pain and have a calming effect. The medications used are known as opioids. These drugs

will not cause you to lose consciousness. Systemic analgesics usually are given as a shot or through an intravenous (IV) line. This is a

small tube that is placed into a vein through which medications or fluids are given.

What are the side effects and risks of systemic analgesics?

Side effects are minor and include itching, nausea, vomiting, feeling drowsy, or having trouble concentrating. Opioids can affect your

baby's breathing and heart rate for a short time. Your baby may be drowsy, which can make it harder for your baby to breastfeed in the

first few hours after birth. You may not be able to get systemic analgesics within the hour before delivery.

What is nitrous oxide?

Nitrous oxide is a tasteless and odorless gas used as a labor analgesic by some hospitals. It reduces anxiety and increases a feeling of

well-being so that pain is easier to deal with. Nitrous oxide is mixed with oxygen and inhaled through a mask. A woman holds the mask

herself and decides when she will inhale. It works best when a woman begins inhaling 30 seconds before the start of a contraction.

What are the side effects and risks of nitrous oxide?

Nitrous oxide is safe for the mother and the baby. Some women feel dizzy or nauseated while inhaling nitrous oxide, but these sensations

go away within a few minutes.

What is local anesthesia?

Local anesthesia is the use of drugs to prevent pain in a small area of the body. The anesthetic drug is injected into the area around the

nerves that carry feeling to the vagina, vulva, and perineum. Local anesthetics provide relief from pain in these areas. The drug also is

used when an episiotomy needs to be done or when tissues need to be repaired after childbirth. When used to relieve pain during

childbirth, the drug is given just before delivery.

What are the side effects and risks of local anesthesia?

Rarely, a woman may have an allergic reaction to a local anesthetic or may have nerve or heart problems if the dose given is too high.

Local anesthesia rarely affects the baby.

What are regional analgesia and regional anesthesia?

Regional analgesia and regional anesthesia are used to lessen or block pain below the waist. They include the epidural block, spinal

block, and combined spinal–epidural (CSE) block. The medication includes an anesthetic